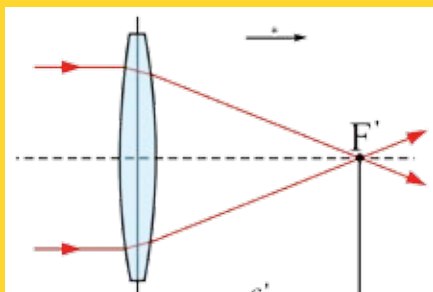


HOW YOU TEST IN A RETAIL STORE

After you've assimilated the above information, you should have a good idea of the type of camera that you want and once you're clear on that, it's time to settle on a specific model. How do you do that? The quickest way is to first glance through the specifications. Ignore things like scene modes, megapixels, digital zoom and smile detection and look for things like manual control options, Wi-Fi support (for convenience), and other things that you think you need.

Performance

1 Initial preparation: If you're going to test cameras, you need a few items with you. Firstly, you need to carry your own memory card with you. Load it into the camera that you want to test and record all images on that card so that you can check image quality at your leisure. Another essential item is a white sheet of paper (more on that later) and, if you're willing to setup your own



scene to test, an assortment of items to create said scene including:

- A piece of cloth with noticeable texture
- An assortment of colours in the form of paint bottles, threads, crayons, etc.
- Some object with fine, precise detail such as a wristwatch
- If possible, a card with an 18% grey background

2 First impressions: To test the capabilities of a camera, first take a photo in low-light. Even if you're in a store, try to take the camera to a darker region of the store and take a photo of something, anything. Ideally, you'll need to take a photo of a surface with a lot of fine detail like, say, the face of a wrist watch or a textured surface of a dress. What you're looking for is detail, the amount of noise in the image, especially in the darker regions.

Depending on what sort of camera you're looking at, don't expect miracles because most cameras will struggle here and you're only

looking for comparatively better performance among the cameras you're looking at.

Take pictures of people, with and without the flash, try to get images in neutral lighting (such as in daylight), images of movement (this could simply be crowds walking, people on an escalator, etc.).

3 Focus: To check the camera's ability to focus and the focussing speed you just need to try to focus on various subjects in various lighting conditions and with various backgrounds and subjects. Also photograph moving objects and check focus speed and the ability to track said object.

Another thing to check for is the camera's ability to focus on multiple subjects at various distances (depth-of-field). To do this just get a bunch of friends to stand in a group at various distances from the camera and take a photo while focussing on the centre of the group and you need to see if everyone is in focus.

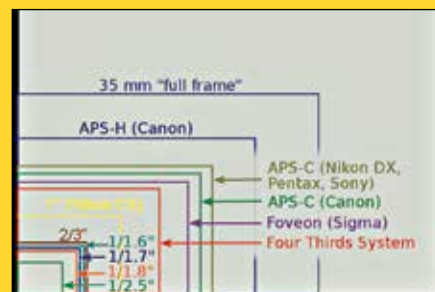
4 White balance: The colour tones that a camera displays is very dependent on its ability to adjust to various lighting conditions. The easiest way to test for this is by using a white sheet of paper (ideally you'd need



to use an 18% grey card such as this one: <http://digit.in/1SeOD46>) and take photos of that sheet under tube lights or fluorescent bulbs, under incandescent bulbs (even table lamps) and in daylight. Make sure that the camera is set to spot metering though. If the camera is good,

the white sheet of paper should look white (or close enough) in all lighting conditions.

5 ISO: This is an easy test. Just setup your scene if you can, if you can't just look for a scene with consistent lighting. Choose a location for your camera and if the option is there, lock white balance and focus. Set your ISO to its lowest value and take a photo and keep taking photos at progressively



higher ISO values. You need to examine each and every image for noise and decide on what you think is tolerable. The higher the ISO, the better the camera's performance in low light.

Compact digital cameras will usually manage good performance up to ISO 200, better ones might manage decent images at ISO 400. Cheap DSLRs should give you acceptable images up to ISO 800 and good cameras will easily manage ISO 1600 and beyond.

6 Resolution: This is a test of the ability of a camera to resolve fine details and is not to be confused with MegaPixels.

Now we use the WG-13 Resolution Target (Google it) for this and you can too. You can purchase an approved test chart from certain photography stores or print one out yourself. All you need to do to check image resolution is to place the target at a fixed distance from the camera lens (we keep it at 6" from the camera) and set the camera to its highest MP setting and lowest ISO. Capture the image and examine it on a good computer screen at 100%